We were preparing to travel to Canberra the day after the Sydney Test to play a first-class fixture when we heard that Bhajji had been banned for three matches. We had had enough. It was just not acceptable and we decided it was time to take a stand against the judgement. We did not agree with what the referee had done and felt that the hearing at Sydney had been something of a farce. We informed the BCCI of the players' feelings and held a team meeting to decide what to do about it.

Anil Kumble and I took the lead and it was unanimously decided that we would boycott the tour if Bhajji's ban was upheld. Anil is one of the politest cricketers I have known but he is also very strong-minded. I have great admiration for the role he played as captain during this controversy. We decided to lodge an appeal against the ban and, in a gesture of protest, we also decided not to travel to Canberra – even though we had already loaded all our cricket gear into the bus. It was time for stern words and strong action.

The BCCI was behind us all the way and duly lodged a formal appeal contesting the ban. Mr VR Manohar, one of India's legal luminaries, was handling our case. We had regular conversations with him and provided him with all the relevant details. I must reiterate that we were very serious about the boycott. If Bhajji's ban was upheld, it would mean an acceptance of guilt and imply that Bhajji had racially abused Symonds, which he most certainly had not. We were fully prepared to accept the consequences of walking out of a tour, knowing that such an action might have resulted in the ICC banning the Indian team. The issue was now bigger than just Bhajji. Indians all over the world felt slighted and we felt it was our responsibility to stand up for our cause.

Having made our decision, we needed to find some way of reducing the tension. In the end we went to Bondi Beach and played a game of volleyball. It had a magical effect. It served as a fantastic team-bonding session and helped give us the determination to carry on. Unsurprisingly, perhaps, the media followed us wherever we went, particularly Bhajji. On a lighter note, I remember saying to him that he must be the second most popular man in the world after Michael Jackson, with so many cameras following him. In fact, I called him MJ for some time during and after the controversy.

Third Test, Perth, 16–19 January 2008